

A SHIFTING LANDSCAPE

From NFL to ISL, tracing Indian football's journey from **reform to uncertainty.**

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Indian football enjoyed its golden era from 1951 to 1962, and those who witnessed those times often reminisce fondly about the days gone by. However, nostalgia aside, football in the country did not follow the most professional approach back then, with most clubs playing in state leagues or select nationwide tournaments.

2. Popularising the game: One of the main challenges the AIFF faced was ensuring that football reached a wider audience. In September 2006, it signed a 10-year television and media contract with Zee Sports to broadcast the upcoming new I-League, along with other AIFF-organised tournaments and select international matches of the Indian national team.

4. Breakdown of the partnership: Despite the 10-year contract, the AIFF terminated the deal in 2010, just four years in, due to differences between the two parties regarding payment and marketing.

6. Birth of the ISL: Around the same time, franchise-based leagues were gaining popularity in India, especially following the success of the Indian Premier League (IPL). Taking a cue from this model, the AIFF, with Reliance's backing, launched the Indian Super League (ISL) on October 21, 2013.



1. First steps: In 1996, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) decided to overhaul the domestic structure by launching the country's first national league, a semi-professional tournament called the National Football League (NFL). It began with 12 teams spread across two zones (West and East), with matches played at neutral venues.

3. Going pro: After 11 seasons of the NFL, the AIFF moved to further professionalise the sport by launching the I-League in 2007. It adopted a more traditional format, where teams played home and away fixtures.

5. Start of the Reliance era: After Zee Sports, the AIFF brought Reliance Industries on board. It signed a new 15-year, ₹700 crore deal with Reliance and the International Management Group (IMG).

7. Initial years: Despite the ISL's fresh approach to Indian football, it initially lacked official recognition from the Asian Football Confederation (AFC) and FIFA. The I-League remained India's official league, meaning ISL teams were not eligible to qualify for the AFC Champions League and AFC Cup.